testing (CBT) from 2027.

But computerisation alone cannot address the deeper failures afflicting the education system. Enrolment in higher education institutions is now about 45 million, 31.5 per cent higher than in 2014-15. Gross enrolment ratio has risen from 23.7 to 30. Female gross enrolment has overtaken male gross enrolment, PhD enrolment has nearly tripled, and the number of colleges has grown from 38,498 to 46,624. But much of the growth has been driven by private providers, faculty recruitment has lagged. Against an AICTE (All India Council for Technical Education) norm of 15-20 students per teacher, private colleges average 28 and public colleges 47. For every 100 additional students, fewer than one teacher is added. Less than 39 per cent of universities have National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC) accreditation.

The result is a small, globally competitive tier at the top, uneven public universities in the middle, and thousands of under-resourced institutions at the bottom, issuing degrees whose value in the labour market is increasingly uncertain. According to the Graduate Skill Index 2025, only 42.6 per cent of graduates are considered employable; just about 45 per cent of engineering graduates are fit for jobs in their core field. Formal vocational training reaches only 3-8 per cent of India's workforce; it is 75 per cent in Germany and

VOX POP

"TRUST MUST BE PROTECTED"



RAIDURGAM JAISHREE NAGRAJ | 21
Osmania University graduate and UPSC aspirant, Hyderabad

Even our freedom fighters protested. If raising our voice for our rights is anti-national, then yes, we are anti-national. But, then, ask yourself—what remains of democracy? This is not just a struggle for today's students; it is a struggle to protect the trust on which the competitive examination system stands. If those in constitutional office cannot carry out their responsibilities, they must accept the consequences.

GROUND ZERO

A TIDAL WAVE

The sights, smells and soundbites at Jantar Mantar

By **AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR**

The first thing you noticed was the smell. Before the slogans, or the stage, or the sea of phones raised towards it. It was the smell of sweat under rain-dampened T-shirts, of rajma-chawal gone bad in the afternoon sun. Of over-ripe bananas, wet cardboard and the sharp antiseptic odour of disinfectant sprayed on the ground.

Regardless, a young woman went around, black trash bag in hand, asking everyone out, "Anyone has trash?" A plastic bottle, a paper cup, a biscuit wrapper, a disposable spoon, she collected them all. "We are here to protest, not litter," she said. "We gotta clean up the trash ourselves." She was Soumya, 25 years old, a resident of Dwarka.

Jantar Mantar was swarming with people like her. One group took turns distributing drinking water; two young women held aloft cartons of Parle-G biscuits as they moved through the crowd. A metal container full of khichdi hung from each forearm of a man who called out for those unfed. On the stage, the speakers appeared tired but patient, telling the organisers: "Thank you for your support. Please form a line."

Some students had come with parents; some had lied to their parents to be there. Young men had taken leave from work; others had stepped off an express train and walked straight to Jantar Mantar, their bags stuffed with books, water bottles, posters, even the tricolour. A lady was there at the protest only because her US-based daughter asked her to. "We were also students until a few years ago and we know how hard it is to secure a job after you graduate," said Kanishka, 26, who works in real estate. "When we saw how students were beaten up and tear-gassed, we decided to come and show support."

Khalid, a tailor from Bhajanpura, was there with his family—standing firm against the crush of the crowd. "My sisters appeared for NEET in 2024 and nothing happened," he



"My sisters appeared for NEET 2024 and nothing happened. Today, I am here for the future of my 10-year-old daughter"
– KHALID, *Tailor, Delhi*